

Sump Pump Failure Flooded Basement — Action Checklist

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DIAGNOSE THE PROBLEM

- ❑ **Diagnose the Problem:** Test the float switch by manually filling the pit with water to see if the pump activates, because stuck, misaligned, or sunken switches are the most common failure point and may not require a full pump replacement.
- ❑ **Diagnose the Problem:** Perform a motor bucket test by unplugging the pump, lowering it into a water-filled bucket, and plugging it directly into a GFCI-protected outlet to determine if the motor itself is functional or dead.
- ❑ **Diagnose the Problem:** Inspect the discharge line exit to verify it is at least 6 inches above grade and directs water away from the foundation, because buried or improperly sloped exits will pump water right back toward your basement.
- ❑ **Diagnose the Problem:** Assess your pump's horsepower rating against your water table conditions, because a 1/3 HP pump may be undersized in high water table areas and should be upgraded to 1/2 HP or higher.

FIX THE PRIMARY PUMP

- ❑ **Fix the Primary Pump:** Install a check valve on the pump outlet to prevent water from flowing back into the pit after shutdown, because without this valve the pump cycles repeatedly on the same water and wears out faster.
- ❑ **Fix the Primary Pump:** Replace the entire sump pump unit rather than just the switch for greater long-term reliability, because reputable brands like Zoeller or Wayne sell dependable 1/3 HP submersible pumps for \$150-250 that most homeowners can install themselves.
- ❑ **Fix the Primary Pump:** Ensure the discharge line exits above ground level and slopes away from the foundation at least 10-20 feet, because water that pools near your foundation will simply re-enter the drainage system and flood your basement again.
- ❑ **Fix the Primary Pump:** Size your replacement pump correctly for your climate zone and typical rainfall intensity, because a pump sized for normal conditions will overflow during extreme weather events when you need protection most.

ADD BACKUP PROTECTION

- ☐ **Add Backup Protection:** Install a battery backup pump system with a 12-volt marine battery to maintain protection during power outages, because grid failures occur most frequently during the severe storms that also cause flooding.
 - ☐ **Add Backup Protection:** Add a secondary pump alongside your primary unit to provide redundancy when water volume exceeds what one pump can handle, because even a working main pump can be overwhelmed during extreme rainfall.
 - ☐ **Add Backup Protection:** Consider a water-powered backup pump for extended power outages that exceed your battery capacity, because during prolonged storm-related outages your battery backup will eventually drain without this secondary option.
 - ☐ **Add Backup Protection:** Budget appropriately for your protection tier based on your basement's finished state and flood history, because full dual-pump systems with battery backup typically cost \$3,000-4,000 but provide the comprehensive protection needed for homes with repeated flooding.
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Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.